

Târoot

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Figure 1: Târoot: mixed reality installation

ABSTRACT

Târoot is an extended reality (XR) art installation exploring memory, heritage, and introspection through a multi-sensory ritual. Blending virtual, augmented, and physical realities, the work reimagines a tarot-like experience rooted in the artist's childhood memories of stories told by her grandmother in Tehran. Within an intimate, softly lit space, the viewer is guided to draw from a custom-designed deck of cards representing the past, present, and future. Each card unfolds through sound, 3D animation, and symbolic elements such as family narratives, medicinal herbs, and mythic figures. The experience culminates in a tangible ritual: the creation of a personalized herbal tea recipe generated from the cards, which the participant prepares and drinks on-site. Târoot bridges storytelling, ritual, and technology to connect the virtual with the deeply personal and real.

Index Terms: Digital Art, Mixed Reality, Multisensorial Interactive Installation

1 INTRODUCTION

Târoot is an extended reality (XR) art installation that explores the connections between memory, heritage, and introspection. The

artist invites the viewer to join her in a multi-sensory card-drawing ritual that unfolds across multiple realities. More than a traditional tarot or divination game, Târoot is a journey into rediscovering the old stories the artist's grandmother used to tell her as a child, during afternoon nap times in Tehran; stories that lingered after she left her home country, Iran.

2 RELATED WORK

Recent research in extended reality (XR) has emphasized its capacity to function as a medium for memory, narrative, and embodied experience rather than solely as a tool for visual simulation. Oskouei et al. demonstrate how virtual reality can operate as a “vessel” for exploring personal and collective memories, highlighting XR's potential to evoke emotional engagement through immersive storytelling and artistic practice [3]. Complementing this perspective, Jiang's study on multi-modal interactive XR environments foregrounds user experience as a central concern, arguing that meaningful engagement emerges when narrative, interaction, and sensory modalities are integrated within immersive systems [2]. This shift toward participatory and experiential design aligns with broader discussions of multisensory interaction in XR, where the inclusion of non-visual senses—such as sound, touch, and smell—is shown to enhance presence, emotional resonance, and memory recall [1]. Târoot builds on these approaches by combining virtual and augmented reality with physical ritual elements, aromatic materials, and participatory storytelling, positioning XR as a framework for the experiential transmission of personal and cultural memory rather than a purely representational technology.

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3 CONCEPTUAL AND THEMATIC POSITIONING

The questions at the heart of Târoot resonate closely with the theme of the 2026 XR Gallery, “(Re)Imagine: Bridging the Past, Present, and Future through Immersive Experiences.” The work examines how the continuum of extended realities can act as shelters for displaced memories—memories that no longer belong to a specific place, yet continue to inhabit the individual. It asks whether immersive media can function as time-and-space capsules for transmitting personal narratives across generations, preserving mental and emotional landscapes that might otherwise fade or disappear.

In a world shaped by migration, displacement, and ongoing cultural transformation, notions such as motherland and mother tongue become increasingly abstract. A sense of belonging—once evoked through the voices of elders, familiar scents, and everyday gestures—gradually weakens. As an immigrant artist, the creator of Târoot seeks to translate her grandmother’s stories into an experiential form that can be seen, heard, and even tasted, transforming remembrance into a multisensory dialogue between presence and absence.

From a research–creation perspective, Târoot explores the intersection of immersive storytelling, sensory design, and embodied cognition through a collaboration between the artist and an XR research laboratory. The installation combines XR interaction design—through a seamless traversal across multiple layers of reality—with sound composition and tangible ritual gestures to investigate how immersive technologies can evoke empathy and foster continuity across cultures and generations. By blending extended reality with sensory interaction, Târoot reimagines immersive technologies as instruments of emotional continuity and cultural resilience: spaces in which personal and collective memory can be curated, preserved, and re-experienced through embodied acts of remembrance.

4 IMPLEMENTATION OF THE TÂROOT EXPERIENCE



Figure 2: The visitor installed in front of the cards deck

The installation takes place within an intimate, semi-enclosed space veiled by light drapery (Fig. 1). The floor is covered with a traditional carpet, at the center of which stands a low table draped with an embroidered cloth. On it lies a custom-designed deck of cards created especially for this experience (Fig. 2). The visitor sits on a cushion before the table. Nearby, a second table holds bowls filled with aromatic herbs and spices, along with a teapot and cups (Fig. 3). The lighting is warm and subdued, enveloping the space in a calm atmosphere. Sitting beside the participant, the artist, or a mediator, invites them to put on the headset placed on the central table and begin the journey. The experience opens in virtual reality with an introductory scene about the grandmother’s life and presence. It then seamlessly transitions into augmented reality, where the viewer interacts with three physical decks of cards: the past,



Figure 3: The visitor prepares the final herbal tea from the personal recipe

represented by old family stories and the lessons they carry; the present, represented by medicinal herbs that nurture the body and mind; and the future, represented by angels and demons that may guide or challenge what lies ahead. Each card reveals a unique narrative through an original sound composition and 3D animation. The session then extends into reality, as each card has a hidden value and stories generate a personalized herbal tea recipe. The recipe is printed on-site by a small thermal printer, allowing the viewer to follow the instructions, prepare their own tea, and enjoy drinking it within the installation’s soothing environment: a final ritual that bridges the sensory, the virtual, and the real.

5 CONCLUSION

Târoot demonstrates how extended reality can serve as a vessel for personal and cultural memory, transforming storytelling into a multisensory, participatory ritual. By weaving together virtual, augmented, and physical layers with narrative, sound, and olfactory elements, the installation creates a space where presence, absence, and memory intersect. In doing so, it reimagines immersive technologies not just as tools for representation, but as instruments for emotional continuity, cultural resilience, and intergenerational dialogue.

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